



MONTHLY UPDATE

Public debate and participation in policymaking: monthly update, August 2026

Edition of 2026-09-06-3 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

33 places. Every block below is carried verbatim from that place's own monthly update, where it was written, sourced and checked; nothing is written here.

BENIN · BURKINA FASO · CAMEROON · CHAD · CONGO · COTE D'IVOIRE · DR CONGO · EGYPT · ERITREA · ESWATINI · ETHIOPIA · GABON · GHANA · GUINEA · KENYA · LESOTHO · LIBERIA · MALAWI · MALI · MAURITIUS · MOROCCO · NAMIBIA · NIGER · NIGERIA · SEYCHELLES · SOMALIA · SOUTH AFRICA · SOUTH SUDAN · TANZANIA · TOGO · TUNISIA · UGANDA · ZAMBIA

The place reports do not share one window; the period above is the range they span.

Benin

Internet governance was taught rather than legislated. A school on the subject [was held in Ouidah with human rights at the centre of its programme](#). It is a training event; the record held names no policy process it feeds into.

Burkina Faso

The same organic law creating the merged communications and data-protection authority folds the broadcasting regulator into it, transferring its mandate subject to promulgation; neither text is held and no commencement, seat or leadership is stated.

Cameroon

The state set itself a public venue for the question its record does not answer. The posts and telecommunications ministry is [hosting the 2026 national Internet Governance Forum in Yaounde from 18 to 20 August](#), on the theme of moving from fragmentation to interoperability and positioning data as the foundation of interoperable digital public infrastructure, with a plenary on a possible national data-governance strategic framework. The base holds no government interoperability layer and no data-governance framework, so the plenary's subject is an absence rather than an instrument. What is held is a preview: no programme document, participant list or prior edition, and no outcome.

The 2026 national Internet Governance Forum [met at the Palais des Congres in Yaounde from 18 to 20 August](#) under the theme of moving from fragmentation to interoperability and making data the backbone of public digital services. No resolution, communique or follow-up mechanism came out of it.

Chad

On 4 August the Haute autorité des médias et de l'audiovisuel [announced](#) that it suspends, "jusqu'à nouvel ordre", examination of applications to create online newspapers. The regulator presented the freeze as implementation of its 2026–2028 three-year strategic plan, one axis of which is to clean up the profession and better address "information disorder", and said it would study new arrangements for governing online newspapers with all stakeholders. The communiqué carried no date of its own, set no end date, no published criteria and no transitional treatment for applications already filed, so the outlets already licensed become a closed list for the duration.

A [national internet governance forum devoted to artificial intelligence is in preparation](#), with no date, venue or agenda yet announced.

Congo

The month's governance news is a prosecution. An international observatory [recorded continued judicial harassment of the defender Ghislain Ondele Kanga and the opening of his trial](#). The record held carries no state response to the account.

Cote d'Ivoire

The month's one entry here is research rather than an instrument. A study [documented cyclical online gendered violence against election candidates in this country and one other](#). No regulatory response, platform obligation or reporting route stands against it on the ledger.

DR Congo

A [standing consultation mechanism between the ministry and the sector network was agreed at a working session on 6 August](#), after the dispute over the digital-sector tariff. No constituting text, membership or meeting schedule is stated, and the agreement is known from a communiqué carried by the state news agency.

The audiovisual and communications council and the press-freedom council [formalised an institutional partnership by memorandum](#) after two days of work on 19 and 20 August 2026. No work programme, joint power or first action under it is on file.

Egypt

Two administrative reforms are stated and neither is dated. The head of the Council of State told circuit presidents the Council [continues to implement an integrated digital transformation plan](#) to speed litigation, naming no system, date or deliverable — the only first-hand record that this branch has a digitisation programme at all. A [proposed cut of the VAT credit-refund period to four months, three for smaller firms](#), still awaits its legislative steps, and will not meet its objects while the problems obstructing proof of balances remain.

Eritrea

Outside consultation reached Asmara. A water-security project [held two rounds of geodesign workshops in July 2026 with more than twenty government, academic, private-sector and non-governmental participants, alongside a hydrological-modelling training session for Eritrean technical experts](#). It is the convener's own account of process, and it sits against a state the record elsewhere describes as silencing criticism systematically.

Eswatini

The regulator drew a line in public. ESCCOM [stated that cyberbullying is a criminal offence under the computer crime statute](#). Stating an existing offence is a step short of enforcing it: the record held carries no prosecution, complaint volume or reporting route created alongside the statement.

Ethiopia

A project on [climate-change disinformation and information integrity across African digital environments launched in August 2026](#), focused on Uganda and Ethiopia and supported by a UNESCO-led global initiative. It combines research mapping how climate disinformation spreads and who drives it with a fact-checking masterclass at the 2026 internet-freedom forum, online training for journalists and civil society, and tracking of African governments' communications ahead of the November 2026 climate conference. No budget or duration is stated.

Gabon

The regulator [established a tripartite dialogue forum at Libreville on 20 August](#), seating itself, the operators and consumers. It is the first standing consultation channel the base holds for this sector, and no meeting schedule, published minutes or complaints route follows from the announcement.

Ghana

The statistical service put a number on what digitisation is being asked to fix. Its governance series records citizens reporting demands for unofficial payments [rising from 51% in the first half of 2025 to 69% in the second](#), and the service names digitalisation, fee transparency and public education as its response, citing a marked fall in bribery at the passport office after digitisation and saying the Office of the Chief of Staff has directed the ten institutions the series flagged as high-risk to report back on remediation. The passport-office comparison is asserted without a before-and-after figure, and the series measures reported demands rather than cases proven.

The same week the ministry took the governance argument outward and inward at once: it [convened an Accra workshop with a policy-monitoring organisation and a trade endowment on digital governance, regulatory coordination and international digital-trade engagement](#), framed against the national artificial-intelligence strategy, the coders programme and the continental digital trade protocol; and its deputy minister [urged information-management professionals to secure and better manage government data as artificial-intelligence use grows](#). Neither produces an instrument, and the national data strategy has been in development since 2024.

Guinea

Neither the regulator ARPT, the operators nor the internet service providers issued an explanation for the social-media restriction, and the silence then had to cover more than a restriction: [a total two-hour national outage on 7 August, across mobile and fibre alike, was traced to the state landing-station operator, whose officials and the regulator both declined to explain it](#). The precedent is on the record rather than inferred: under the post-coup transition a government spokesman owned a three-month digital cut and said that in Guinea the internet is not a right.

Kenya

One item moved in this window and it is a contested procurement rather than a policy debate: a former deputy president [told reporters on 24 August 2026 that the electoral commission's results-transmission contract specifications were tailor-made for a single South Korean bidder, that every other competitor has gone to the](#)

[procurement appeals board](#), and that the firm has failed at every election it has taken part in. He says he is still documenting the claim; the report names neither the company nor the contract, and no commission or appeals-board response is on file.

The commission answered on 27 August. It [said no company has been awarded the 2027 election-technology tender](#), that tenders for the management system's hardware and for ballot papers are frozen at the Public Procurement Administrative Review Board on a request for review, and that the documents were published on 11 August with generic performance-based specifications. The forum that would normally host this argument met the same week: KICTANet [published the report of the nineteenth Kenya Internet Governance Forum](#), held with more than 300 participants and confirming Kenya as host of the global forum, in Nairobi for the first time since 2011.

Lesotho

The state opened a channel for hearing what its digital services are actually like to use: a [public survey opened on 9 August covering access, usability, trust and skills gaps across online applications, digital payments and health and education platforms](#), run with the United Nations development programme as part of a digital readiness assessment. No closing date, sample target or commitment to publish the results is stated, so what it will settle is not yet knowable.

Liberia

On 30 July the Anti-Corruption Commission [confirmed it had forwarded a complaint about the telecoms traffic-monitoring arrangement to its investigation unit](#). No evidence has been publicly produced and no findings made.

The month's one channel built to hear from the public rather than about it was relaunched by donors. UNICEF and UNFPA [relaunched the U-Report youth feedback platform on 13 August](#), with Irish embassy support and under a joint programme with the government, giving young people an encrypted SMS channel to answer polls on health, water and sanitation and other social issues, with responses analysable by county and a target of at least 8,000 reporters. The channel runs on one operator's SIM cards, which bounds who can take part.

Malawi

A [four-day regional consultation on artificial intelligence and digital inclusion opened in Lilongwe on 19 August](#) under ministerial patronage, gathering public, private, academic and civil-society input. It is the fourth consultative event of the window and, like the three before it, has produced no output document.

Mali

The same 3 August the cybercrime pole [sentenced Chahana Takiou to 12 months with six suspended](#) on a charge of undermining the credit of the state through the judicial institution, over remarks at a Bamako media forum in June 2026 arguing that journalists should be tried under press-offence law.

Mauritius

The month's sharpest domestic contribution was an argument about priority. A [named analyst published on 2 August](#) the case that contract enforcement rather than technology limits growth, citing the World Bank's 2025 indicators — 42.2 on ease of commercial dispute resolution against Singapore's 73.3 — and more than 70,000 cases pending at end-2025. Its digital prescription is digitalised case management alongside a small-claims process. Analysis, not evidence.

The month's other forum was external in origin. At the national Internet Governance Forum, founded by the Halley Movement, the [Blockchain for Good Alliance](#) and the exchange [Bybit](#) met the Vice President and the ICT minister to discuss artificial intelligence, cybersecurity and digital-trust frameworks for small island developing states. The record held is the visiting alliance's own press release; no forum programme, outcome document or attendance figure is held.

Morocco

Simplification is law and is not yet practice. A member's written question to the digital transition ministry put the ombudsman's 2025 finding on the record: [agencies still ask citizens for paper copies of documents the administration already holds electronically, and impose undisclosed extra conditions](#), which is what the procedural simplification law was passed to stop. No ministry answer is held. The complaint from the other end is about coverage rather than paperwork: residents of one Sefrou commune [are asking for new or strengthened transmission stations, describing reliable connectivity as a condition of schooling, work and emergency access](#).

Namibia

The dominant mobile operator [publicly rejected customer claims that it takes data](#), its data adviser telling a trade-fair discussion on 30 August 2026 that billing is consumption-based, attributing rapid depletion to video streaming and hotspot sharing, and distinguishing consumption from bundle expiry. The operator said it is building a control letting customers opt in or out of airtime being spent on data once a bundle runs out; no implementation date was given. It is the one argument in this section held with a company rather than a ministry, and the only one that produced a stated product change.

Niger

A state observatory monitored the country's media and platforms through a security incident and then told the media owners what it found. The national communication observatory [monitored traditional media, online media and the main publicly accessible digital platforms from 28 August to 1 September and presented its conclusions in Niamey on 2 September, reporting exceptional information intensity in the hours after shots and explosions were reported near an air base at the international airport, the effects of an information vacuum, divergence in how the facts were characterised, and social networks accelerating both information and disinformation with old images and out-of-context video circulated](#). Its president said the meeting was not a trial of the media. The monitoring report itself is not published, so what was measured, over what sample and under what legal basis is not established.

Nigeria

The month's one item is a formal demand rather than a policy change: a rights organisation and the Guild of Editors [jointly called on 24 August 2026 for enforcement of the Cybercrimes Act to be suspended pending repeal or revision, arguing that the 2024 amendment failed to cure the defect the ECOWAS Court of Justice identified in 2022 when it ruled the original section 24 vague, arbitrary and in breach of the African Charter](#). No government or prosecutorial response is on file.

Seychelles

Parliament amended the [Seychelles Broadcasting Corporation Act in June 2026](#), transferring greater power over the appointment and dismissal of the public broadcaster's board from the independent Constitutional Appointments Authority to the President. The base holds no primary text of the amendment; what it holds is Afrobarometer's August dispatch, which reports it citing Broadcast Media Africa and the International Press Institute, and sets it against the survey it was publishing.

That survey, fielded in 2025, finds [45% of Seychellois calling the media somewhat or completely free, down from 51% in 2022, with 52% saying it is not very or not at all free](#) — a decline recorded on a media environment that Reporters Without Borders ranked 35th globally in 2026, up ten places. Appetite for oversight is not in doubt: [78% want the media to investigate government mistakes and corruption constantly, and 85% back the right to publish without government interference](#).

Somalia

A former prime minister published an argument that [the country cannot afford another term of lost wealth](#). It is a signed opinion on resource governance rather than a policy position, and it carries no digital component of its own. It is held because public argument of this kind is otherwise absent from this ledger, and the absence is itself the finding: a base that records instruments and no debate about them cannot show a reader where the pressure on those instruments comes from.

South Africa

The rights commission put a position on the record about who should arbitrate what is true online. Launching its policy brief on information integrity, [a deputy justice minister said government should not become the custodian of truth on disinformation, while warning against leaving the information environment to private platforms' algorithms](#), grounding the balance in the constitutional rights to expression, political participation and access to information. It is a brief rather than an instrument, and no legislative proposal follows from it on the record.

South Sudan

The e-government contract came under an allegation the minister denies. The information technology minister [denied two documents alleging a US\\$15 million influence-buying transfer by the contracted firms](#). The documents' authenticity is contested and the record held carries no independent verification either way. Separately, a published argument [held that South Sudan needs digital payments but also needs the ability to follow the money](#) — a case the month's other news makes concrete.

Tanzania

The month's one finding about political speech came from outside the state. A civil-society research organisation [documented online gendered violence against election candidates as cyclical across successive elections in Tanzania and Côte d'Ivoire](#), timed to a national election period. No regulator, electoral commission or platform publishes a comparable measurement, so the only quantification of the problem the record holds is the researcher's own.

Togo

The regulator spent August on the road rather than on rules. Its [seventh national consumer-sensitisation tour ran from 3 to 28 August with consumer associations and operators](#), briefing them on electronic-communications rights. At the Kara leg, [local officials asked the regulator to widen its remit to all economic operators](#) — a request to be regulated more, not less.

The room where digital policy is argued is now on record: the [national internet governance forum](#) has run annually since 2010 and held its twelfth edition on 19 June, with every digital regulator on the panels alongside civil society. Civic space around it is rated [Repressed at 29 of 100](#), unchanged since 2020.

Tunisia

Parliament's own case file arrived, and it makes the revision of the 2022 cyber-offences decree-law measurable rather than announced. The bill was [deposited on 20 February 2024, referred to committee on 10 April 2025, carries 38 sponsors and has not been voted](#); its operative text — the amendments themselves — is not published on the assembly's own page, which is a dated absence rather than an unsought one. [The committee named the revision its top priority in January 2026](#); two and a half years after deposit, that priority has produced no vote.

Uganda

Public argument in the window is being made by civil society rather than in Parliament. A joint civil-society submission [was filed for the country's fourth-cycle Universal Periodic Review](#), the review itself not yet held, and a [climate information integrity project was launched](#) with a regional research organisation and a UN agency. Both are external channels: nothing on this ledger records a domestic consultation the state itself opened in the month.

Zambia

The same Postal and Courier Services Bill consultation — the only open public call for written comment on a Zambian instrument the wiki holds for the whole window — closed three days after the call for written submissions was reported, with no submission count, published response or consultation report held.

On 1 August the Human Rights Commission disclosed that its case review meeting had considered 105 alleged violations linked to the election period, of which 62 were resolved administratively.

The election itself, on 13 August, produced the fullest external account of the country's digital systems the base holds. Observer missions recorded a [hybrid digital and manual voter-registration system with an online pre-registration portal, logging 8,786,300 registered voters, up 25% since 2021](#). A domestic coalition [found election-day process largely transparent but flagged an online-only accreditation system that blocked 11 accredited monitors, and the electoral commission's refusal to share the voters register](#). The European mission found online free expression unduly curtailed under the 2025 Cyber Security Act amid arrests for speech offences, and a regional media institute [recorded a journalist detained for two weeks under the Cyber Crimes Act and judged the access-to-information law and decriminalised defamation paper victories undermined by the two 2025 statutes](#). These are preliminary statements; no final report, government response or commission account of the accreditation and register decisions is held.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

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CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/topics/gov-discourse/gov-discourse-monthly.html
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